Protecting the Dignity and Privacy of Shelter Clients

Guidance for workers in congregate shelters to support the cultural needs of clients in communal living

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Client Care, Disaster Disability Integration

Considerations

- Clients in shelters may feel uncomfortable and uncertain in a communal living setting and need our support and guidance to help them adjust to their new surroundings.
- Red Cross clients have many cultural backgrounds and value systems, with varying levels of concern about modesty, decency, and privacy.
- Empathy and communication are fundamental elements in protecting the dignity of clients.
    - Red Cross workers strive to help clients feel safe and establish privacy from the public and authorities in the dormitory area.

- Related **Mass Care Group Standards:**
    - Mass Care Service Site Requirements

- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations

What to do

Listen and Collaborate

- Listen carefully to client concerns and suggestions regarding personal dignity and accommodate them as much as possible.
- As needed, request guidance from Disaster Disability Integration, Disaster Health Services and Disaster Mental Health.

Address shelter layout and setup concerns

- Establish dressing areas by using privacy screens or small rooms adjacent to the dormitory.
    - Obtain shower curtains and tension rods for use in shower areas when necessary.

- Establish areas for families with small children.
    - Provide a private infant changing area.
    - Provide a breastfeeding room or screened area. Breastfeeding in public is legal in all states and permitted in Red Cross shelters, but some clients prefer the privacy and quiet these areas provide.
    - Provide a space where families with infants can be separate from others if they wish. The space protects unvaccinated infants and reduces noise across the dormitory.

- Provide blue rooms (or sensory kits) for clients in need of a low sensory environment such as autistic clients and those suffering from dementia if possible.

Address service concerns

- Establish a private area for personal or sensitive discussions with clients to respect client privacy during the sharing of information. These may be used for disaster health, mental health and spiritual care discussions, along with those for any other private/confidential issues.
- Provide bags to clients to discreetly carry feminine hygiene, incontinence, and other personal products distributed in the shelter.

Related Articles

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters
Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Providing Assistance for Clients Experiencing Homelessness
Details for workers in shelters and DRO Headquarters on supporting unhoused clients

Serving Clients Legally Required to Register with Government Agencies
Guidance for workers on how to lawfully and discreetly support individuals required to register with government agencies during disasters.

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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